Blue Meridian Partners 2022 Messaging Guidance

FOR STAFF

This document is meant to be a reference guide for staff. It includes key message points about Blue Meridian that can be used for written and spoken communications as of **March 2022.**

blue meridian partners

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CONTENT NOTE:
This document helps guide the way you speak and write about Blue Meridian Partners and our work. This iteration includes updates from the previous version (last issued in fall 2020) to reflect our current reality. We will continue to refine this in coming years to show our latest work and to align with the implementation of our strategic imperatives.

Core Messaging Language

BOILERPLATE

Below is standard language that briefly summarizes Blue Meridian and is intended to be used wholesale in written communications and materials at the corporate level.

SINGLE SENTENCE BOILERPLATE

Blue Meridian Partners is a pioneering philanthropic model for finding and funding scalable solutions to problems that limit economic and social mobility for America's young people and families in poverty.

SINGLE PARAGRAPH BOILERPLATE

Blue Meridian Partners is a pioneering philanthropic model for finding and funding scalable solutions to problems that limit economic and social mobility for America's young people and families in poverty. We know solutions exist, but even the most promising strategies cannot reach far enough, fast enough without significant, long-term investment. In order to meet the scale of the problem, we provide transformative capital paired with capacity-building support and strategic advice, empowering visionary leaders to dream bigger and vastly expand their impact, influence, and reach. With an investor mindset, we support strategies that address challenges from cradle to career, working both nationwide and within specific communities. We recognize that economic mobility is inextricably tied to racial equity. Therefore, we make investments that tackle systemic inequities that both hinder opportunity for Black, Indigenous, and Latinx people and other communities of color and limit the flow of capital to social sector leaders of color. Our partnership of leading philanthropists pool resources to invest more efficiently and effectively than any single funder could alone. Ultimately, Blue Meridian's goal is to transform the philanthropic marketplace in order to improve the life trajectories of millions of young people and families across America.

"BLUE MERIDIAN PARTNERS" VS. "BLUE MERIDIAN"

In an initial written reference to the organization begin by using "Blue Meridian Partners" in full. The one exception is if the term "partners" or "partnership" is used in close proximity within the same sentence. Following a first reference, you can shorten to "Blue Meridian."

Core Messaging Language

FRAMEWORK

MULTI-PARAGRAPH FRAMEWORK

Below is a framework that includes key message points about Blue Meridian that can be leveraged and combined with other content for more extended written communications and materials. Rarely would one use this exactly as is.

Introduction

Blue Meridian Partners is a pioneering philanthropic model for finding and funding scalable solutions to problems that limit economic and social mobility for America's young people and families in poverty.

Value to Investees

We know that solutions to many of these problems exist. But even the most promising strategies cannot reach far enough, fast enough without significant, long-term investment. With an innovative, investor mindset, Blue Meridian Partners provides the flexible, upfront capital that visionary social sector leaders need to dream bigger, pursue long-term change, and vastly expand their impact, influence, and reach. We channel right-sized funding to organizations with an established track record of success and a vision for achieving scale, positioning leaders to focus on growth and execution rather than chasing the next grant. Our flexible investments range in size depending on the portfolio, but we are prepared to invest as much as $100 million in a single organization or strategy based on milestones met over multiple phases. Beyond the dollars, we provide investees with strategic advice and capacity-building support, from collaborating on their growth plans to advising on building their evidence base and identifying measures of impact. The depth of Blue Meridian's engagement, paired with our bold level of capital investment, makes a transformative difference for investees.

Value to Partners

As a partnership of leading philanthropists, Blue Meridian has aggregated more than $3 billion in capital to date. By pooling their resources, our Partners invest more effectively and efficiently than they could as individuals, while sharing the costs, risks, and successes. Our team provides best-in-class expertise, including rigorous sourcing and due diligence on a steady flow of investment opportunities and performance assessments on existing investees. Through their interactions with the management team, investee leaders, and each other, our Partners engage in a dynamic learning community.

Investing Approach

Blue Meridian invests in solutions that boost economic and social mobility by combating the many complex drivers of poverty. Our investment approach seeks to foster the conditions that support individuals in reaching key success markers from cradle to career, such as school readiness or securing meaningful employment. Across our portfolios, visionary social sector leaders create pathways to opportunity by addressing critical challenges largely stemming from historic and systemic injustices, such as unplanned pregnancy or interaction with the criminal justice system. Core to our work is investing in nationwide and place-based approaches – which complement and reinforce one another – because we believe it's important to both touch many lives across America and address problems specific to certain communities in order to create impact at scale. We recognize that structural inequities have excluded Black, Indigenous, Latinx, and other people of color from power and opportunity in this country for centuries. Therefore, we are investing to close the funding gaps for organizations with leaders who share experiences with the people they serve and to ultimately dismantle systems of racial inequity.

Core Messaging Language

FRAMEWORK

MULTI-PARAGRAPH FRAMEWORK

Below is a framework that includes key message points about Blue Meridian that can be leveraged and combined with other content for more extended written communications and materials. It is a rarely would one use this exactly as is.

Portfolios

Blue Meridian has committed over $1.5 billion in investments through five portfolios that amplify national and local solutions that drive economic and social mobility. Our **Nationwide Solutions** portfolio makes significant, long-term investments that expand successful, evidence-based solutions to a national scale. Recognizing the importance of community and living environments in determining life outcomes, the **Place Matters** portfolio invests in local partnerships focused on the specific needs of their community as well as in an ecosystem of supports to help those partnerships achieve their goals. **The Studio @ Blue Meridian** embraces experimentation and iteration, providing capital and tailored strategic advice to organizations working to overcome barriers on the road to ambitious scale, with particular focus on increasing the flow of funds to leaders of color. Through our **Justice and Mobility Fund**, we invest in solutions that boost economic mobility and improve the life trajectories of people impacted by the criminal justice system. And, exemplifying our ability to pivot to address emerging needs, our **COVID-19 Response** connected timely capital with organizations providing immediate support to people most affected by the pandemic; through this portfolio, we are currently investing in systemic improvement and innovation in education, supporting children to re-engage successfully in school.

Vision

We believe that creating equitable economic and social opportunity is achievable, but we need to scale investments for maximum impact in order to create lasting change at scale. With a pioneering spirit, we are committed to innovating our approach by continually exploring new ways to expand our portfolios and support a wider range of social sector leaders. Ultimately, Blue Meridian Partners seeks to transform the philanthropic marketplace, maximizing the impact of collaborative investing to improve the life trajectories of millions of young people and families across America.

Brand Foundations

ATTRIBUTES & AUDIENCE

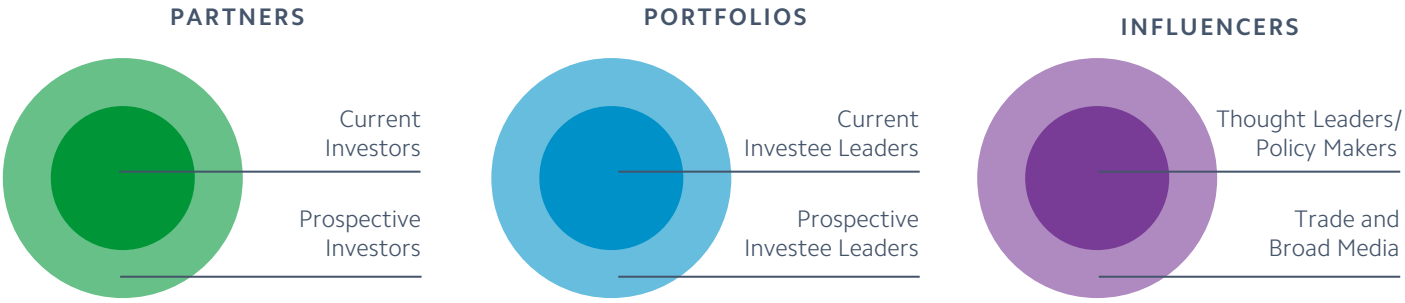
Below are foundational elements of the Blue Meridian brand created for internal use to help inform your communications as brand ambassadors.

BRAND ATTRIBUTES

We have five core attributes which we aim to infuse into all aspects of the brand.

There are three auxiliary attributes which guide brand voice and visual design.

CORE AUDIENCES



Brand Foundations

POSITIONING

Below are key positioning statements that reflect Blue Meridian's origin, purpose, and continued work.

WHY WE EXIST

At Blue Meridian Partners, we are united by a shared belief that young people and families across the US should have an equal opportunity to live productive and healthy lives. Entrenched poverty that persists from generation to generation is a seemingly intractable social issue – one that disproportionately affects people of color due to systemic inequities. Blue Meridian meets the scale of this problem with right-sized investments in solutions that work across domains to expand access to opportunity for all Americans. To tackle such vast challenges, we work to scale the most promising approaches at both a nationwide level, to maximize their reach and impact, and at a regional level, because we know that people's life chances are inextricably tied to where they live. Through an investment model that pairs boldness with rigor, we are working to shift the funding paradigm in the philanthropic marketplace, creating a new normal where social sector leaders are empowered with unrestricted, flexible capital so that they can dream bigger and pursue longer-term impact.

HOW WE DO IT

Blue Meridian's investment approach unlocks substantial philanthropic capital in support of solutions that can help change the life trajectories of millions of young people and families. To date, we have pooled more than $3 billion and are investing in a range of catalytic organizations across five diverse portfolios. While pooling capital is essential, the power of Blue Meridian's model lies also in the depth and rigor we bring to our collective investments, which complement and reinforce one another at national and local levels – and across key drivers of poverty – to create sustained, far-reaching impact.

Our funding partners engage in different ways and at different levels based on personal goals and areas of interest. By pooling philanthropic resources, Blue Meridian's Partners can invest more effectively and efficiently than any investor could individually – amplifying impact while sharing the costs, risks, and successes. Our team provides best-in-class expertise, including rigorous sourcing and due diligence on a steady flow of investment opportunities as well as performance assessments, and Partners engage in a dynamic learning community.

We identify visionary social sector leaders and invest the flexible, upfront capital they need to dream bigger, look to the long term, and dramatically expand their impact, influence, and reach. Anchored by our carefully tested, performance-based investing approach, Blue Meridian Partners makes strategic investments; we are prepared to invest as much as $100 million or more in a single organization or strategy. Beyond the dollars, we provide our investees with strategic advice and capacity-building support, from collaborating on their growth plans to advising on building their evidence base and identifying milestones that measure impact.

WHERE WE COME FROM

We come to this work with a decades-long track record of innovation in philanthropy and a comprehensive investing approach developed at the Edna McConnell Clark Foundation (EMCF). Incubated at EMCF, Blue Meridian is an independent philanthropic organization that builds on EMCF's performance-based investing approach, leadership in aggregating capital, and strong co-investing relationships – which EMCF developed over 20 years. In 2016, EMCF announced its intent to spend down its remaining resources over the next decade; as a founding General Partner, EMCF continues to support Blue Meridian as part of its limited-life strategy.

Talking Points

GENERAL AUDIENCES

Below are guidelines for live conversations **with General Audiences.** Please adjust the tone to be more informal or direct (e.g., use 2nd person "you") when appropriate and to best fit your own speaking style.

ABOUT BLUE MERIDIAN PARTNERS

- At Blue Meridian, we find and fund scalable solutions to problems that limit social and economic mobility among America's young people and families in poverty.
- We are employing a bold, effective approach that seeks to transform the philanthropic marketplace.
- Our work addresses some of the root causes of economic inequity and lack of opportunity from cradle to career.
- We focus on creating pathways to opportunity for our country's young people and families by investing in strategies that work. In particular, we seek to close gaps in equity and opportunity for Black, Indigenous, and Latinx people, who have historically suffered from racial injustice and systemic barriers to prosperity.
- Our investees address critical roadblocks, challenges, and systems that perpetuate poverty across generations, including mass incarceration, foster care, unemployment, and unplanned pregnancy, among others.
- We recognize both the power of scaling evidence-based solutions nationwide to touch more lives and the importance of local and regional approaches that work, knowing that people's life chances are inextricably tied to where they live, learn, and work.
- Blue Meridian is currently a partnership of 19 leading philanthropists who believe that we can achieve bolder, more comprehensive impact by pooling resources and investing ambitiously. They include individuals such as X and Y and institutions such as X and Y.
- Our value to the group of Partner funders is rooted in our team's best-in-class expertise – including rigorous sourcing and due diligence on investment opportunities and performance assessments on existing investees – as well as in engagement with a dynamic learning community.
- Together, we invest the capital that visionary social sector leaders need to exponentially grow their impact, influence, and reach.
- We think of Blue Meridian's model as innovative within the social sector; Blue Meridian's leaders have been honing how to best pool and deploy capital for over 20 years, and we envision a future philanthropic marketplace that channels capital more rationally and robustly to leaders with strategies that work to solve major social problems.
- We are also constantly learning, exploring, and testing new strategies to grow our work and achieve our mission.

Talking Points

GENERAL AUDIENCES

Below are guidelines for live conversations **with General Audiences.** Please adjust the tone to be more informal or direct (e.g., use 2nd person "you") when appropriate and to best fit your own speaking style.

ABOUT OUR APPROACH

- Blue Meridian brings together investors and social sector leaders. We pool philanthropic resources in order to scale the most promising strategies that boost economic and social mobility.
- We know solutions exist, but even the most promising strategies cannot reach far enough, fast enough without significant, long-term investment.
- Blue Meridian Partners' collaborative model channels robust, flexible capital to social sector leaders with the vision and capacity to pursue impact at scale. Those leaders, freed from chasing piecemeal funding, can operate from a position of strength in focusing on expansion and execution.
- To date, we've pooled over $3 billion and are investing across five diverse portfolios of evidence-based strategies.
- For philanthropists without "ready-made" vehicles for investing or those looking to create greater impact at scale, our team provides best-in-class expertise, including rigorous sourcing and due diligence on investment opportunities as well as performance assessments on existing investees, to streamline the investing process.
- Investors benefit from an engaged learning community and an ongoing flow of vetted investable opportunities, and they can pursue different levels of investment with specified goals, focus areas, and regions of interest.
- This model enables us to make significant, flexible, long-term investments that range in size depending on the portfolio. We're prepared to invest as much as $100 million in a single organization or strategy. Our capital is based on milestones met over multiple phases.
- Social sector leaders benefit from flexible resources, which are typically the hardest to raise, allowing them to think big and plan for the long term.
- Beyond the dollars, we provide investees with strategic advice and capacity-building support, from collaborating on their growth plans to advising on building their evidence base and identifying milestones that measure impact.
- We understand that the drivers of poverty are complex and often intersect. Because of that, we invest through multiple portfolios designed to open pathways to opportunity.
- We are committed to closing gaps in equity and opportunity for Black, Indigenous, and Latinx people and, in particular, expanding the level of social sector capital directed to organizations with Black, Indigenous, and Latinx leadership.
- We bring a performance-based, investor mindset to our philanthropy. We view our grants as investments and measure success in terms of social impact.

Talking Points

GENERAL AUDIENCES

Below are guidelines for live conversations **with General Audiences.** Please adjust the tone to be more informal or direct (e.g., use 2nd person "you") when appropriate and to best fit your own speaking style.

ABOUT OUR INVESTMENTS

- We understand that the drivers of poverty are complex and often intersect. Because of that, we invest through multiple portfolios designed to open pathways to equity and economic and social opportunity from cradle to career.
- We invest in both nationwide and place-based strategies – which complement and reinforce each other – to amplify impact across the country as well as address problems within specific communities.
- We recognize that key markers – such as school readiness or finding meaningful employment – must be met throughout people's life stages in order for them to access opportunity and thrive. We take a comprehensive approach and select strategies working to help people reach these markers or prevent obstacles that hold them back, such as unplanned pregnancy or involvement in the criminal justice system.
- These investments unleash the potential of visionary social sector leaders to dream bigger, plan for the long term, and ultimately touch more lives.
- We provide significant, upfront, flexible capital in order to meet the scale of the problem with right-sized resources.
- We invest in solutions with established track records of impact, as well as those with strong leadership and compelling models that may be at earlier stages of assessing their impact and building their evidence base. Key to our selection is a vision for scaling.
- We continue to build and diversify our investments and currently have committed $X billion through five portfolios. Each portfolio supports a variety of organizations, all focused on building pathways to opportunity for young people and families in poverty.
- Our approach is flexible. It enables us to invest in specific issue areas, like criminal justice and childhood development, while also remaining responsive to emerging challenges, like supporting an equitable recovery from the COVID-19 crisis.

Talking Points

SOCIAL SECTOR LEADERS

Below are guidelines for live conversations **with Social Sector Leaders.** Please adjust the tone to be more informal or direct (e.g., use 2nd person "you") when appropriate and to best fit your own speaking style.

- We invest in expanding solutions to the problems that limit economic and social mobility for America's young people and families.
- We know solutions to many of these problems already exist. And we know that they come from innovative and visionary social sector leaders with strategies that work to help young people and families move out of poverty.
- We identify and rigorously vet the most promising strategies, which have an established track record and a vision for scaling. We then provide the upfront capital that enables visionary leaders to dream bigger.
- We equip leaders to invest in their organization's capacity building and data gathering. They can apply flexible resources – which are typically the hardest to raise – to refine their models, plan for the long term, and vastly expand their impact, influence, and reach.
- Our approach allows investees to focus more on execution, performance, and results – rather than on individual project fundraising.
- Investees are at the center of our work. In addition to investing flexible capital, we offer capacity-building support and strategic or operational guidance to investees. This can include collaborating on growth plans, supporting efforts to build their base of evidence, and creating milestones to measure impact.
- We invest in both nationwide and place-based strategies that amplify impact across the country as well as target problems specific to regions and communities.
- Blue Meridian seeks to close systemic funding gaps and believes the most powerful solutions are shaped by leaders whose lived experience and identity reflects the communities they're working to strengthen.
- We are committed to expanding access to capital for leaders of color, who have long faced steep barriers to large-scale investment.
- We conduct our own sourcing and vet organizations through seven investment criteria. These include a compelling vision, strong leadership, evidence of effectiveness, a demonstrated commitment to racial equity, and prospects for significant growth.
- By pooling resources from multiple investors, we increase efficiency and ease the burden of managing multiple funders with different priorities. For example, while we have 19 Partners, we require investees to submit only one set of milestones and one performance report.

Talking Points

FOR POTENTIAL FUNDERS

Discussions with prospective investors should be handled by the Investor Relations team. Please channel all inquiries to that department. Still, we are providing this to assist you in the event that you engage with a potential funder and need to introduce our work.

- Blue Meridian is a partnership of leading-edge philanthropists investing in scalable national and local solutions that drive economic and social mobility in the US.
- Today's philanthropists want to invest in what works. In contrast with the for-profit world, however, philanthropy lacks "ready-made" vehicles for investments and has limited infrastructure in place to channel large-scale investments into high-impact solutions.
- By pooling capital, we are prepared to make significant, long-term investments of up to $100 million or more in a single organization or strategy.
- Our aggregated capital model enables investors to amplify impact in social sector investing, while sharing the costs, risks, and successes. In addition, our model provides best-in-class expertise, with our expert team conducting rigorous sourcing and due diligence on investment opportunities. Investors actively engage in a dynamic learning community through quarterly meetings and knowledge-sharing among leading philanthropists.
- Blue Meridian employs a comprehensive approach to investing in the best available strategies aimed at boosting economic mobility from cradle to career. Our portfolio of investments addresses root causes of inequity and advances key drivers of economic mobility across domains, including early childhood development, workforce success, and criminal justice reform, among others.
- We provide transformative capital for social sector leaders to unlock their full potential and develop roadmaps for scaling. We invest flexible, upfront capital to scale impact over time and amplify solutions to systemic racial inequities and the injustices they create.
- Blue Meridian's investment approach has been tested and honed over two decades, beginning at the Edna McConnell Clark Foundation. Through this approach, we are able to build trust-based, performance-driven relationships with visionary social sector leaders and scale the most promising solutions to poverty in the US.
- Blue Meridian creates an opportunity for Partners to engage at different levels of investment with tailored goals and focus areas. Our Partners are united by a shared commitment to changing the life trajectories of millions of young people and families in the US.
- We streamline the investing process of our Partners. The management team's work on behalf of the partnership removes the burden on an individual philanthropist or institution.
- We serve as an "outsourced" solution for philanthropists who do not want to augment their existing team or those who seek to amplify their impact in specific issue areas.
- Our leadership team brings cross-sector experience, deep domain expertise, and a shared commitment to increasing economic mobility in the US. Our team finds exceptional strategies, structures right-sized investments, provides ongoing strategic counsel to an organization's leadership, monitors performance against milestones, and reports regularly to Partners.
- We anchor all our investments in plans developed and owned by our investees and complement them with our own unique performance-oriented investing methodology, which is a core part of our value-add to both our investees and our Partners.
- Since our founding in 2015, we have aggregated over $3 billion to support social sector leaders and scale evidence-based solutions. We have paid out over $1 billion of that capital to investees, with even more committed towards multi-year investments.
- We are still in the early days since our formation, and we very much welcome new Partners as we build out our next chapter to create lasting impact at scale.

Talking Points

COLD CALL INQUIRIES

For Cold Call Inquiries About Receiving a Blue Meridian Investment

This script is for use in cold calls about a Blue Meridian investment or follow-ups from organizations post survey submission.

- At Blue Meridian, we invest in scalable solutions to problems that limit economic and social mobility for America's young people and families in poverty.
- We appreciate the opportunity to learn more about your organization and the work that you do.
- To start off, I'd like to point you to Blue Meridian's investment criteria. Have you reviewed our seven criteria listed on our website (on the For Grantseekers page)?
    - **IF NO:** Please review that. If you're on the website, you can find it in the top navigation tab under "For Grantseekers." We don't accept unsolicited proposals. But if your organization meets the criteria outlined, we recommend that you complete the brief Interest Survey form at the bottom of that page.
    - **IF YES:** If your organization meets the criteria outlined on our website's "For Grantseekers" page, we recommend that you complete the brief Interest Survey form that you see further down on the page.
- We'll carefully review the information you submit.
- But please note that our sourcing and selection process is highly rigorous.
- Due to the volume of requests we receive, we can only reach out to organizations with demonstrated alignment with our criteria.
- **Because of that, you will not need to follow up with us.** [If asked again, please continue to reinforce this message.]
- Thank you for your interest in Blue Meridian Partners.

Portfolio Language

OVERVIEW

It is important for all staff to be conversationally fluent about all BMP portfolios. The following provides summary language for each portfolio to support high-level communications about each fund. More in-depth message guidance can be found in portfolio-specific documents outside of this guide. Please reach out to Brand & Comms team to develop customized language to fit different needs, audiences, or space constraints.

OUR CURRENT FUNDING RUNS ACROSS FIVE PORTFOLIOS:

NATIONWIDE SOLUTIONS

Blue Meridian's Nationwide Solutions portfolio makes significant, long-term investments that bring evidence-based solutions to national scale in order to solve problems that limit economic mobility for young people and families trapped in poverty.

PLACE MATTERS

Blue Meridian's Place Matters portfolio aims to improve economic and social mobility in communities across the US through investments in place-based partnerships and catalytic supports.

THE JUSTICE AND MOBILITY FUND

The Justice and Mobility Fund is a philanthropic collaboration that invests in boosting economic mobility and improving the life trajectories of people impacted by the criminal justice system.

THE STUDIO @ BLUE MERIDIAN

The Studio @ Blue Meridian seeks to empower social sector leaders by providing flexible resources – both coaching and capital – that help accelerate their organizations' readiness to significantly scale their impact, influence, and reach.

COVID-19 RESPONSE

Blue Meridian's COVID-19 Response portfolio began with direct cash assistance and support in accessing public benefits and is now providing capital and technical assistance to education innovators in order to re-engage children in school.

Portfolio Language

NATIONWIDE SOLUTIONS

SINGLE SENTENCE BOILERPLATE

Blue Meridian's Nationwide Solutions portfolio makes significant, long-term investments that bring evidence-based solutions to national scale in order to solve problems that limit economic mobility for young people and families trapped in poverty.

SINGLE PARAGRAPH BOILERPLATE

Blue Meridian's Nationwide Solutions portfolio works to boost economic mobility for young people and families by making significant, long-term investments to bring evidence-based solutions to the causes and drivers of poverty to national scale. We believe in taking what works – programs and strategies that are already producing results in one or more states or across several cities – and making right-sized investments to bring those approaches to scale nationally. There is no single solution to the numerous problems that trap young people and families in poverty in the US, so we invest in solutions across multiple domains that seek to boost economic mobility in a variety of ways. We identify visionary social sector leaders and invest the flexible, upfront capital they need to dramatically expand their impact, influence, and reach. These large-scale, long-term investments of $100 million or more in a single initiative or strategy provide the unrestricted growth capital required to help promising strategies deepen their impact and expand nationwide.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Blue Meridian's Nationwide Solutions portfolio makes significant, long-term investments to address the causes and drivers of poverty by bringing evidence-based solutions to a national scale.
- These strategic, long-term investments of $100 million or more in a single initiative or strategy allow organizations to plan for the long term and accelerate efforts to scale their impact, influence, and reach nationwide.
- We know there is no single approach to solve the problems that limit economic mobility, so we invest in a variety of domains, such as early childhood development, foster care, workforce success, and family planning.
- In addition to growth capital, we provide our investees with strategic counsel, such as collaborating on their scaling plans and identifying milestones to measure success.
- The Nationwide Solutions portfolio is Blue Meridian's founding portfolio, where we first advanced our pioneering approach to philanthropy by making investments that are right-sized to meet the scale of problems we seek to address. The lessons learned through this work will continue to inform Blue Meridian's evolving set of portfolios.

Portfolio Language

PLACE MATTERS

SINGLE SENTENCE BOILERPLATE

Blue Meridian's Place Matters portfolio aims to improve economic and social mobility in communities across the US through investments in place-based partnerships and catalytic supports.

SINGLE PARAGRAPH BOILERPLATE

Blue Meridian's Place Matters portfolio aims to improve economic and social mobility among young people and families in communities and neighborhoods across the US. To break the seemingly inextricable link between a person's ZIP code and their life chances, we believe in the power of communities coming together across sectors, identifying shared goals, and creating interventions specific to their needs. Through a comprehensive strategy, we are investing in both place-based partnerships – a community-driven, outcomes-focused approach – and the necessary ecosystem of supports to catalyze the success of each partnership. Core to Blue Meridian's overall investing strategy, Place Matters reflects our long-held belief in place-based work as a powerful avenue for progress towards our mission of improving the life trajectories of young people and families in poverty. Ultimately, we aim to leave communities in control to shape their own destinies and amplify the array of solutions they can scale to achieve lasting impact.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Research shows that a person's geography is all too often their destiny. That is, where you are born and live in the US, and the socioeconomic circumstances that shape your upbringing and neighborhood, tend to dictate the access, resources and opportunities you will have throughout your life.
- The devastating effects of systemic racial inequity in underserved communities across the country have prevented many people from thriving and deprived them of access to resources, networks, and policies that are essential to improving economic and social mobility.
- Place-based partnerships are a key way to ensure that solutions are designed and implemented appropriately community by community. They create cradle-to-career opportunity pathways that build on each individual's and community's assets, while attending to their remaining needs.
- We are currently in the early phases of implementing the Place Matters strategy and will use the learnings and results from initial investments in planning across 14 places and eight catalytic supports to inform future strategic direction.
- As philanthropic investors, Blue Meridian leaves power in the hands of community leaders; we do not generate place-based work, nor are we the "doers." Rather, we are funding organizations in support of work that is being led and done by others and already existed in some form.

Portfolio Language

THE JUSTICE AND MOBILITY FUND

SINGLE SENTENCE BOILERPLATE

The Justice and Mobility Fund is a philanthropic collaboration that invests in boosting economic mobility and improving the life trajectories of people impacted by the criminal justice system.

SINGLE PARAGRAPH BOILERPLATE

The Justice and Mobility Fund is a philanthropic collaboration created by Blue Meridian Partners and the Ford Foundation, with significant support from the Charles and Lynn Schusterman Family Philanthropies, that invests in boosting economic mobility and improving the life trajectories of people impacted by the criminal justice system. Mass criminalization and incarceration has become one of the most critical civil rights issues of our times – currently, 77 million people in America have criminal records, and millions more interact with the justice system each year. Today this issue assumes even more urgency as America addresses the devastating health and economic effects of the COVID-19 pandemic on top of the country's entrenched patterns of racial injustice and over-criminalization – both of which continue to exact a crushing toll on people of color, especially the Black community. The Justice and Mobility Fund brings significant new resources to the field, including flexible capital and support for organizations' planning and capacity-building efforts. It aims to scale powerful solutions that promote economic mobility for people at key touchpoints throughout the justice system, with a current focus on boosting employment for individuals with criminal records. As America pursues an inclusive post-pandemic recovery, it is essential to reduce convictions and incarceration, advance racial equity, and create meaningful economic opportunity for justice-involved individuals in order to help break America's cycle of poverty and injustice.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- The Justice and Mobility Fund is a philanthropic collaboration that invests in visionary social sector leaders who are advancing solutions that boost economic mobility and improve the life trajectories of people impacted by the criminal justice system.
- Justice and Mobility is a collaboration between Blue Meridian Partners and the Ford Foundation, with significant support from the Charles and Lynn Schusterman Family Philanthropies. To date, we have invested $168 million in a range of leading organizations.
- Involvement with the criminal justice system presents severe barriers to upward economic mobility. It limits people's ability to get an education, maintain stable housing, and qualify for employment opportunities and public benefits, among many other challenges.
- We invest in powerful solutions across key touchpoints of the criminal justice system to reduce and mitigate the impact of incarceration and criminal records on economic mobility. It is essential to lower the number of people entering the system and eliminate barriers that block people's economic advancement.
- Going forward, the Fund is focusing on promoting living-wage employment for the 77 million people with criminal records, especially people released from jail or prison.

Portfolio Language

THE STUDIO @ BLUE MERIDIAN

SINGLE SENTENCE BOILERPLATE

The Studio @ Blue Meridian seeks to empower social sector leaders by providing flexible resources – both coaching and capital – that help accelerate their organizations' readiness to significantly scale its impact, influence, and reach.

SINGLE PARAGRAPH BOILERPLATE

The Studio @ Blue Meridian invests in social sector organizations to accelerate their readiness to significantly scale their reach, impact, and influence. These investments seek to empower visionary leaders who are ready to think big and prepare for transformational growth by providing access to the flexible resources – both coaching and capital – required to test and enhance their approaches to solving social challenges. Blue Meridian launched The Studio to fill clear gaps in the social sector funding market that restrict leaders looking to experiment and iterate upon their existing models – gaps that are exacerbated by persistent racial inequities, further limiting the flow of funds to Black, Indigenous, and Latinx leaders. In order to advance an equitable recovery from the COVID-19 crisis, The Studio is especially focused on supporting organizations whose work directly addresses pressing needs confronting communities hit hardest by the crisis. The Studio is a central pillar of Blue Meridian Partners' commitment to collaboration and experimentation in pursuit of boosting the economic mobility of those trapped in poverty.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- The Studio @ Blue Meridian seeks to empower social sector leaders to accelerate their readiness to significantly scale their impact, influence, and reach.
- Investments from The Studio provide visionary leaders with the opportunity to think big and accelerate their readiness for greater scale through access to flexible resources – both coaching and capital – needed to further test and enhance their approaches to solving intractable social challenges.
- The Studio @ Blue Meridian launched in 2019 and to date has invested nearly $150 million in 16 exemplary organizations working on a range of barriers to scale.
- Most recently, The Studio has supported organizations addressing pressing needs arising from the COVID-19 crisis to advance an equitable recovery, given longstanding inequalities that have been exacerbated by the pandemic's economic impact.
- Recognizing the urgency with which we must support students whose learning was disrupted by COVID-19, The Studio's next set of investments will focus specifically on addressing educational inequities.
- The Studio is committed to addressing systemic racial inequities and investing in organizations with diverse leadership teams that reflect the communities they serve and have lived experience shaped by the problems they seek to solve.
- The Studio @ Blue Meridian is a central pillar of our commitment to continuous innovation and learning and of our effort to cast a wider net in search of innovative ideas and diverse leaders.

Portfolio Language

COVID-19 RESPONSE

SINGLE SENTENCE BOILERPLATE

Blue Meridian's COVID-19 Response portfolio began with direct cash assistance and support in accessing public benefits and is now providing capital and technical assistance to education innovators in order to re-engage children in school.

MULTI-PARAGRAPH BOILERPLATE

The COVID-19 pandemic has caused immense, disproportionate harm to the most vulnerable people in the US. Blue Meridian's COVID-19 Response portfolio provides funding to organizations serving the hardest-hit communities in two ways: through direct cash assistance and support in accessing public benefits, and through needed capital and technical assistance to education innovators that help maximize the impact of federal resources on student success and well-being.

Initially, we funded organizations that were providing essential relief to individuals and families experiencing acute economic fallout at the onset of the pandemic – from job loss to lack of affordable housing. Our COVID-19 Emergency Relief investments supported direct cash assistance and improved access to public benefits. The pandemic has also profoundly disrupted the education system, disconnecting millions of students from school. Our COVID-19 Education Recovery investments will provide needed capital and technical assistance to education innovators who are successfully re-engaging children and families in school.

Overall, Blue Meridian's COVID-19 Response efforts will deploy a total of over $230 million to help the most vulnerable populations, across both Emergency Relief and Education Recovery investments. We also continue to support our existing investees in their efforts to address urgent needs in the communities they serve and in their work towards a long-term, equitable recovery.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Blue Meridian's COVID-19 Response portfolio deploys capital to organizations focused on supporting vulnerable communities and the children and families disproportionately affected by the pandemic.
- We recognize that an individual's race, income level, and employment or health status can make them particularly vulnerable to an economic or health crisis. We focus our COVID response work on these disproportionately affected communities.
- Our philanthropic model is built so we can act nimbly when needed. We responded at the height of the pandemic in 2020 with cash assistance and access to public benefits. Now, our Education Recovery investments are responding to the urgent need to address disrupted learning as well as students' physical and mental well-being.
- Blue Meridian has invested over $150 million in Emergency Relief funding to organizations helping the hardest-hit populations through direct cash assistance and access to critical public benefits.
- Blue Meridian has invested over $80 million in Education Recovery in order to help school districts maximize federal resources that will provide academic, physical, and mental well-being supports.
- Overall, our COVID-19 Response efforts will deploy a total of over $230 million across both our Emergency Relief funding and Education Recovery investments.

REDI Language

FRAMEWORK

The language below is for use by staff in written and/or verbal references to Blue Meridian's commitment to racial equity, diversity, and inclusion. Further details about terminology and key phrasing can be found in the REDI Style Guide.

SINGLE PARAGRAPH BOILERPLATE

In order to promote upward economic mobility in communities across the nation, Blue Meridian Partners must address entrenched systems of racial inequity in the United States. Those systems have produced gaping racial disparities in nearly every meaningful measure of opportunity and quality of life, including health, education, employment, income, and the creation and distribution of wealth. We know we can be more effective, innovative, and impactful in solving the problems that trap young people and families in poverty when we proactively address racial inequities and prioritize diversity and inclusion as integral to our organization and our investment approach.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- The gaping disparities we see today in nearly every measure of opportunity and quality of life – including health, education, employment, income, and wealth – are a direct result of structural and systemic racism In the United States.
- We at Blue Meridian Partners recognize that if we are not intentionally and directly focusing on and embedding racial equity in our work, we will not achieve the gains in economic mobility we seek for young people and families trapped in poverty.
- We are in the process of establishing a sound framework for dismantling bias and addressing inequities within our organization, including how we make investment decisions, staff our team, and manage our operations.
- Going forward, we at Blue Meridian hold ourselves accountable to:
    - Ensuring our organizational diversity more fully reflects the communities in which we invest. Over the past few years, we've made significant strides in diversifying our staff, and we'll keep building on that record at all levels of the organization, including our board.
    - Continuing to provide the space and resources for our team to learn, reflect, and grow in the knowledge and skills needed to combat bias and prioritize racial equity in our work.
    - Strengthening our investment approach by emphasizing racial equity and addressing implicit bias in our decision-making processes – from sourcing to ongoing performance management and the steps in between.
- We will focus on closing gaps in equity and opportunity for all people of color and especially for Black, Indigenous, and Latinx people, and strive in particular to expand the level of social sector capital directed to organizations with leaders that reflect the impacted communities.
- We're still in the early stages of this journey, and we are eager to learn from and with our investees, Partners, collaborators, and others who are taking steps every day to build the equitable and just society we seek.

General Guidance

DOs

This section includes high level DOs for all staff. For portfolio specific recommendations, please refer to the individual guides on Brand Central.

What we WILL DO	KEY WORDS TO EMPHASIZE
Proudly celebrate our approach	• Investor mindset • Performance-based • Long-term • Scaling solutions • Tested approach
Lean into our leadership and desired perceptions	• Pioneering/Innovative • Diverse team • Experienced leaders
Embrace our portfolios	• Diverse portfolios of solutions • Increasing economic and social mobility • Complementary national and place-based investments
Highlight the importance of collaboration	• Funding Partners pool resources to unlock substantial capital • Partners share the costs, risks, and successes
Emphasize scale	• Right-sized investments to match the scale of the problem • Flexible capital that encourages big thinking • Touching more lives within communities and across the US • Expanding impact, influence, and reach
Be inclusive when describing our target population, while being direct about those most in need	• Young people • Families • From cradle to career • Especially Black, Indigenous, and Latinx people and communities*
Be straightforward about the barriers that trap specific populations in poverty	• Systemic barriers and inequities • Longstanding injustices, including racism • Underinvestment in communities • Engagement with the justice system
Embrace the thorough vetting process	• Rigorous sourcing and due diligence • Impactful solutions • Seven selection criteria
Embrace REDI	• On a journey • Keeping REDI front and center across our work
Additional Guidance Amplify the work of our Partners, investee organizations, and investee leaders, and ask them to do the same. For additional guidance on communities served, please refer to the REDI Messaging Guidance and REDI Style Guide.	

General Guidance

CAUTION

This section includes Words to Consider Carefully for all staff. For portfolio specific recommendations, please refer to the individual messaging guides on Brand Central.

CAUTION AND ALTERNATIVES	WORDS TO CONSIDER CAREFULLY
Be careful about describing our investees' work as "proven" • 'proven' can be open to interpretation, and often measuring impact takes many years, so we aim for phrases like 'evidence-based,' 'performance-based,' or 'promising' instead	• Proven
Be careful about words that make communities/people served appear unempowered. • Consider disclaimers like 'systemically marginalized' if unavoidable • Consider 'historically underinvested in'	• Vulnerable • Marginalized • Disadvantaged • Minority • Disenfranchised • Poor • Low income
Be careful about talking only about the cohort experience when referencing organizations supported by The Studio @ Blue Meridian. • We've made investments in single organizations (i.e., Vision to Learn) outside of a cohort and we may do so again as we continue to evolve The Studio's investing approach.	• Cohort
Be careful about referring to our business model as "capital aggregation" or "aggregate" funding. • Though we want to remove financial jargon when possible for lay audiences, these terms resonate with investing-savvy audiences • Consider 'pool' or 'pooling' **only when used as a *verb***	• Aggregate • Capital aggregation • Pool/pooling

General Guidance

DON'Ts

This section includes general DON'Ts for all staff. For portfolio specific recommendations, please refer to the individual guides on Brand Central.

What we WON'T DO	WORDS AND PHRASES TO AVOID
Criticize other *specific* philanthropies and philanthropic approaches	• Only • Best in class • Single most
Use words that suggests gambling, given our investments are based in thorough vetting and thought	• Big bet
Refer to Blue Meridian Partners as a "donor collaborative" or "pooled Fund" (noun) because this can indicate a loosely held together group, which does not describe our work. Also do not describe as a "foundation" as this does not reflect our model or legal status.	• Donor Collaborative • Foundation • Pooled Fund (Use "philanthropic model" instead)
Abbreviate our organization name or fund names in official external communications or formal documents as we don't want others to emulate that practice	• "BMP" • "JAM" • "PM" • "NWS" (Except for internal purposes or within close external working relationships like TBG)
Refer to Blue Meridian as its legal entity name or abbreviation with *most* external parties	• "Blue Meridian Partners, Inc." • "BMP, Inc" (Except for internal purposes or communications with lawyers or select vendors with whom this nomenclature is appropriate and agreed on)
Refer to what Blue Meridian funds as "programs" or Blue Meridian's work or any portfolio as a 'program'	• Programs (Use "solution, strategy, initiative, approach, intervention, organization" instead)
Refer to organizations receiving investments through The Studio as "investees"	• "Studio investee" (Use "participant" instead)
Describe our partners as "donors"	• Donors (Use "philanthropist" or "investor" instead, as they suggest more active involvement)

Additional Guidance

- Avoid getting too technical until there is a need to. Keep explanations high-level and in plain speak, trusting that people will ask for more detail when interested.
- Do not let the details of process overtake the importance of value and impact.
- Do not suggest that responsibility or reasons for being in poverty lie in the hands of people and/or communities in poverty

Questions & Answers

FREQUENTLY ASKED Q'S

This section includes frequently asked questions and their subsequent answers. Tougher questions should be directed to Branding & Communications or Blue Meridian leaders.

Q How is Blue Meridian Partners different from other types of Foundations?

A Blue Meridian Partners is pioneering an innovative approach to philanthropy, one that we hope will transform the philanthropic marketplace. We are unique in both our structure and approach. Blue Meridian is legally classified as a 501c3, but we are distinct from a traditional private foundation in that we do not have an established endowment from which we draw to support organizations. Rather, we continually raise capital from Partners to deploy in the form of significant, long-term investments in the most promising solutions that boost the economic and social mobility of young people and families in poverty. For philanthropists, our model offers a ready-made vehicle, allowing our Partners to engage at varied levels depending on their interests. Additionally, our performance-based approach streamlines the investment process by offering best-in-class expertise, including rigorous sourcing and due diligence on a steady flow of investment opportunities and performance assessments on existing investees. For social sector leaders, we provide significant, flexible capital to allow them to dream bigger, pursue long-term change, and vastly expand their impact, influence, and reach. Investments support organizations' evidence-base and capacity building – often the hardest funding for social sector organizations to raise. These right-sized investments free up investee leaders to focus on execution, performance, and results on their path to scale – rather than chasing smaller, fragmented grant dollars.

Q What is Blue Meridian's Place Matters portfolio?

A Blue Meridian's Place Matters portfolio aims to improve economic and social mobility in communities across the US through investments in both place-based partnerships and strategic supports that catalyze their success. To break the seemingly inextricable link between a person's ZIP code and their life chances, we believe in the power of communities coming together across sectors, identifying shared goals, and creating interventions specific to their needs. Core to Blue Meridian's overall investing strategy, Place Matters reflects our long-held belief in place-based work as a powerful avenue for progress towards our mission of improving the life trajectories of young people and families in poverty. Our legacy investments in Tulsa, OK, and Guilford County, NC, have demonstrated that funding partnerships – both between national and regional funders and between private and public funders – can propel meaningful change in a community and generate new opportunities.

Through our comprehensive strategy, we are investing in a dozen place-based partnerships to plan for the future as well as seven other organizations which together form a part of the necessary ecosystem of supports to enable the success of each partnership. Ultimately, we aim to leave communities in control of their own destinies, while amplifying the array of solutions they can scale to achieve lasting impact.

Questions & Answers

FREQUENTLY ASKED Q'S

Q How is Blue Meridian responding to short and long-term challenges created by COVID-19?

A Blue Meridian is committed to addressing both the short- and long-term impacts of COVID-19. The pandemic is causing immense and disproportionate harm to the most vulnerable people in the US, including Black, Latinx, and Indigenous communities in particular. At the pandemic's onset, our COVID-19 Response portfolio supported direct cash assistance and improved access to public benefits through our Emergency Relief investments. Now, our COVID-19 Education Recovery investments will provide much-needed capital and technical assistance to education innovators who are re-engaging millions of children and families who were disconnected from schools due to the profound disruptions that rocked the nation's education system. To date, we have allocated over $230 million across our Emergency Relief funding and Education Recovery investments.

Our philanthropic model allows us to respond nimbly when needed. We aim to realize equitable rebuilding and recovery in communities that are disproportionately impacted by this crisis due to longstanding systemic inequities.

Q Does BMP fund or invest in systems reform and advocacy?

A Blue Meridian invests in a wide range of organizations advancing promising strategies to address some of the root causes of inequity and lack of opportunity affecting communities across the country, including mass incarceration, foster care, unemployment, and more. In order to help change deeply entrenched systems that limit economic mobility, we provide leaders with strategic, flexible support that lets them invest in their people and organizations and build strong coalitions and advocacy efforts. This allows leaders to shift prevailing narratives and public attitudes about poverty – all while innovating and refining their core model. Through our investments, we advance a range of solutions that include, but are not limited to, advocacy and systems reform strategies..

Questions & Answers

FREQUENTLY ASKED Q'S

Q How does one become a Partner?

A Our Partners are united by a shared commitment to changing the life trajectories of millions of young people and families living in poverty in the US. Blue Meridian's partnership structure allows our Partners to pool their philanthropic resources and invest more effectively and efficiently than any individual could alone. By working together, Partners amplify their impact, while sharing the costs, risks, and successes of Blue Meridian's performance-based approach to investing. Blue Meridian creates opportunity for Partners to pursue different levels of investment with specified goals, focus areas, and regions of interest while participating in an engaged learning community. For example, General Partners invest in all portfolios and share decision-making on new investing and performance management. Other investors focus exclusively on one portfolio, such as supporting the Justice and Mobility Fund. To learn more about becoming a Partner, please visit the "Our Partners" page on our website.

Q How can I apply to get into Blue Meridian's portfolio?

A We don't accept unsolicited proposals. Blue Meridian conducts its own extensive research to identify and vet outstanding organizations and strategies that boost economic mobility and change the life trajectories of young people and families in poverty. There is additional information about our process and selection criteria on the "For Grantseekers" page on our website. If you review this information and think your organization is a promising fit, we welcome you to complete the Interest Survey.

Q How does Blue Meridian Partners relate to the Edna McConnell Clark Foundation?

A The Edna McConnell Clark Foundation (EMCF) was one of the first philanthropies to pool funding from philanthropic partners and invest in evidence-based approaches with the potential to have national impact. Blue Meridian's approach builds on this track record, honed by EMCF's nearly two decades of work, which developed practices to identify and fund the most promising youth-serving nonprofits as well as bring philanthropic partners together to pool and amplify the impact of their investments. Blue Meridian leverages EMCF's experience in an effort to further transform the philanthropic marketplace, expanding the EMCF model through larger, more diversified investments over longer periods of time. EMCF incubated Blue Meridian Partners for three years and also serves as one of its founding Partners. As part of EMCF's limited-life strategy, which it announced in 2016, its staff and operations have transitioned to Blue Meridian Partners. Now, Blue Meridian is helping EMCF fulfill its commitments to its Youth Development Fund grantees. Over the next few years, EMCF will continue to invest all its assets in making an enduring impact on the lives of children and families trapped in poverty across the US.

Questions & Answers

FREQUENTLY ASKED Q'S

Q What are the common threads across Blue Meridian's various investments and multiple portfolios?

A Blue Meridian maintains five investment portfolios that complement and reinforce each other in order to expand upward economic and social mobility for young people and families in poverty. Collectively, Blue Meridian's portfolios tackle many complex drivers of poverty – including unplanned pregnancy, foster care, youth unemployment, and criminal justice involvement. Organization-wide, we invest in visionary social sector leaders with solutions that help young people and families meet key developmental and success markers, from cradle to career. We provide right-sized funding to help investees meet the scale of the problem they seek to address, amplifying their impact, influence, and reach. To do this, we take both nationwide and place-based approaches – often within a single portfolio – in order to touch the most lives across America while addressing problems specific to certain communities. Across all of our investing, we are committed to dismantling systems of racial inequity that have excluded Black, Latinx, and other communities of color from opportunity for centuries. Our comprehensive investing approach seeks to increase and strengthen the opportunities for all young people to thrive.

Q Why does Blue Meridian work across various life stages and domains?

A We source the most promising, evidence-based solutions to help young people and families achieve success from cradle to career. Blue Meridian Partners subscribes to a results-oriented approach, acknowledging that individuals' life chances are tied to hitting key milestones of success and development across life stages – from healthy birth and early learning through to adulthood. And hitting such milestones, while avoiding key impediments, such as unplanned pregnancy, unemployment, or involvement in the child welfare or criminal justice systems, has compounding benefits to that individual and to their community. Further, we recognize the need to utilize a comprehensive approach to driving upward economic and social mobility that acknowledges the importance of the surrounding built, social, and economic environments.

Q What is Blue Meridian's value-add for Partners?

A A collaboration of leading philanthropists, our Partners combine their resources in order to invest more effectively and efficiently than they could as individuals, while sharing the costs, risks, and successes. For philanthropists without "ready-made" vehicles for investing, as well as for those seeking to create greater impact at scale, our team provides best-in-class expertise, including rigorous sourcing and due diligence on investment opportunities and performance assessments on existing investees to streamline the investing process. Funders benefit from an engaged learning community and an ongoing flow of investable opportunities, and they can pursue different levels of investment with specified goals, focus areas, and regions of interest. Overall, we serve as an "outsourced" solution for those who may not wish to augment their existing team and/or seek to amplify their impact in specific issue areas.

Questions & Answers

FREQUENTLY ASKED Q'S

Q What is Blue Meridian's value-add for Investees?

A While solutions to many of the problems that trap young people and families in poverty do exist, even the most promising strategies cannot reach far enough, fast enough without significant, long-term investment. With an innovative, investor mindset, Blue Meridian Partners provides the right-sized, upfront capital that visionary social sector leaders need to dream bigger, pursue long-term change, and vastly expand their impact, influence, and reach. We channel flexible funding – which is often the hardest to raise – to organizations with an established track record of success and a vision for scaling, empowering leaders to focus on growth and execution rather than chasing the next grant. Beyond the dollars, we provide investees with capacity-building support paired with strategic and operational advice, including collaborating on scaling plans, assisting with strengthening their evidence base, and identifying milestones that measure impact. Ultimately, if we are successful in our mission, we hope to help transform the philanthropic marketplace such that future social sector leaders with promising solutions have access to right-sized capital that allows them to execute on their bold visions at scale.

Q How does Blue Meridian measure impact?

A Blue Meridian Partners brings a performance-based, investor mindset to our philanthropy, viewing our grants as investments and measuring success in terms of social impact. We make large, phased investments in solutions that have demonstrated a meaningful level of success in boosting social and economic mobility among young people and families in poverty. These investments are anchored on comprehensive scaling plans that serve as blueprints for investees' growth in terms of quality. We align with investees' leadership on annual and end-of-investment performance milestones drawn from these plans. Performance is monitored against these milestones and reported regularly to Blue Meridian's group of investment Partners in order to guide decision-making and channel resources.

The flexible capital we provide our investees can be used by leaders to build measurement and data collection capacity and/or embark on rigorous evaluations in order to better assess their impact and identify areas for improvement. Within Blue Meridian, we maintain a learning mindset and continue to strengthen our own measurement system to capture and understand impact over time.

Glossary

KEY TERMS AND OUR DEFINITIONS

This glossary is focused on key terms that are central to Blue Meridian's approach to philanthropy and appear frequently in this Messaging Guidance and other external content. Our goal here is to clarify for staff how Blue Meridian uses each of these terms, recognizing that this list may evolve over time. We included brief definitions for each word or concept, as well as additional commentary to provide more context for how we settled on each definition. This is not intended to be shared externally.

POVERTY: Poverty refers to an individual's or family's inability to meet basic needs, such as housing, transportation, and food, that often stems from policies, systems, and structures that create obstacles to opportunity.

Addressing the challenges that trap young people and families in poverty is central to Blue Meridian's mission as an organization. This definition provides a baseline for how we think about our investments to promote economic and social mobility. At a minimum, having sufficient resources, including income, to meet basic needs is required in order to experience upward mobility.

MOBILITY: Mobility is defined as the upward trajectory of an individual's economic and/or social well-being. The key drivers include improved economic circumstances, an increased sense of power and autonomy, and a sense of belonging and being valued in the community. The longer-term goal of economic and social mobility rests on the premise that basic needs, such as housing, safety, and food, are met, and that young people and families have a pathway to experience economic and social advancement throughout their lifetimes.

We included a definition of mobility to provide a tether for the definitions of economic and social mobility that follow. Whether written or spoken, we suggest you refrain from using the term mobility on its own externally and instead be more precise in referencing economic and/or social mobility.

ECONOMIC MOBILITY: Economic mobility refers to improving one's financial circumstances within society. It requires access to opportunities that can result in higher earnings or wealth. This is most often measured as an individual's or family's ability to move into a higher economic quintile than their parents (what they were born into) over the course of a lifetime. Meeting basic needs, such as housing, safety, and food, represents a starting point. Blue Meridian seeks to create pathways that advance an individual or family's financial well-being throughout their lifetime.

There are a number of ways that different social sector organizations and experts – including our Partners – define economic mobility. We've grounded this definition in the work and research of Dr. Raj Chetty and the Opportunity Atlas at Harvard University.

ECONOMIC OPPORTUNITY: The circumstances or pathways that are necessary to experience economic mobility. These include living in a safe environment where your basic needs are met, with an adequate school system, the presence of an adequate number of jobs that pay a livable wage, and access to a network that can facilitate connection to opportunities.

As economic mobility and economic opportunity can often be used in tandem, we felt it was important to clarify the relationship between the two terms.

Glossary

KEY TERMS AND OUR DEFINITIONS

SOCIAL MOBILITY: Social mobility refers to the building or strengthening of an individuals' access and connection to networks that are critical to improving social and economic status within a community. It also refers to the relationships that provide opportunity and support a sense of belonging and being valued in a community. Shifts in systems or structures that allow for greater equity often contribute to greater social mobility.

This definition emphasizes the importance of strengthening relationships and networks within one's community and the effect that can have on both an individual's economic mobility and their sense of belonging and value in society.

YOUNG PEOPLE AND FAMILIES: The segment of society our investments intend to primarily support. This encompasses individuals through prenatal, infant, and early childhood years; K-12; and young adult workers, parents, and caregivers. Within this group, we are particularly concerned with those who have been systemically marginalized, such as communities of color – especially Black, Indigenous, and Latinx individuals.

While we know that many organizations may use this terminology, we wanted to highlight the way we think about this segment, as they are central to Blue Meridian's mission, though we recognize some investments touch a broader set of people. We are focused on an all-encompassing definition of "young people and families," without a precise age cutoff, and we're especially focused on those who have faced chronic systemic barriers to opportunities.

SCALE: Scale is defined as expanding the impact, influence, and reach of an organization or a strategy to meaningfully address the magnitude of the challenge(s) being tackled. When we say "meeting scale with scale," we are referring to making large-scale investments to meet the enormity of the societal issue at hand. We acknowledge that our investments alone cannot solve these issues and that many solutions are required, but we instead hope to indicate the need for significant, flexible investments to create impact. We also recognize that there are different pathways to achieving scale – both nationally and within a region.

Scale is at the core of what we do. We are aware that there are others who use "scale" to mean simply increasing an organization's size. At Blue Meridian, we want to focus on an organization's ability to touch more lives, have greater impact with the people they work with, and/or guide changes in policy, practices, or mindsets. This is why we often use the phrase 'increase impact, influence, and reach' to convey our approach to scaling.

INVESTMENTS: We use the term investments/investees in much the same way that other philanthropies use "grants/grantees." This is because of our rigorous approach to grantmaking and our belief that philanthropic success can be measured through social impact rather than financial gain. We aim to support solutions that have the potential to remove barriers to economic mobility on a transformative scale.

This definition provides the "why" for our decision to use "investees" rather than "grantees." We think this term also helps reinforce our rigorous, performance-based approach that incorporates learnings, best practices, and language from both the business and social sectors.

RACIAL EQUITY: Racial equity is the systematic fair treatment of people of all races that results in equitable opportunities and outcomes for everyone. All people are able to achieve their full potential in life, regardless of race, ethnicity or the community in which they live. Internally, we often shorthand this as "REDI."

Now that we've landed our Racial Equity, Diversity, and Inclusion messaging [link], we want to ensure that it is fully incorporated into our Blue Meridian glossary and approach. The above definition draws upon language developed by the Annie E. Casey Foundation.

Glossary

KEY TERMS AND OUR DEFINITIONS

STRATEGIES: We often use "strategies" to describe a social sector organization's approach to addressing a societal challenge. Therefore, we invest in promising or evidence-based "strategies," "approaches," or "interventions" and not "programs."

Synonyms: solutions, interventions, approaches
This definition establishes how we speak and write about the work of the social sector organizations we invest in.

SOLUTIONS: These are strategies that demonstrate effectiveness in boosting economic and/or social mobility. Some solutions are ready for transformative scaling, others still require testing and refinement, but they all, to some extent, have demonstrated efficacy and readiness for expansion. We often use "solutions" to describe what we are investing in and seeking to scale because the approach combats a "problem" that is a driver of poverty and limited economic or social mobility.

Synonyms: strategies, intervention
This definition allows us to differentiate those strategies that are demonstrating the most efficacy, or at least showing the most promise, toward boosting economic and/or social mobility. Additionally, the term "solutions" is encompassing of nonprofits and for-profits, which gives us flexibility in the future.

PERFORMANCE-BASED INVESTING: Blue Meridian first identifies and rigorously vets the most promising solutions in order to invest significant capital over multiple years. We then make an investment grounded in the investee's scaling plan. Each investee works with their designated Managing Director to create a set of milestones based off the scaling plan. Performance is assessed on a regular basis using these milestones in order to report to Partners and determine pay out.

This definition details the process of our rigorous approach to investing and our collaboration with investees to set measurable milestones which determine pay out. If an investment demonstrates regular poor performance, we would not continue to invest.

COMPREHENSIVE FRAMEWORK: Blue Meridian Partners and the communities we invest in subscribe to a results framework. This framework acknowledges that individual success markers must be achieved across life stages, from maternal health/prenatal development to early childhood and adolescence to adulthood. It considers how the surrounding environments – such as public, community, and economic conditions, among others – factor into one's ability to achieve these milestones. Place-based partnership leaders leverage this framework to determine the priority outcomes for their respective community and focus their efforts on those outcomes.

This framework captures a subset of items that impact and influence a person's life. It draws upon research developed by The Social Genome Project – a partnership between the Brookings Center on Children and Families, the Urban Institute, and Child Trends – and supported by multiple other studies.